ters, both British and Indian. This is one hundred per cent non-fiction and everything is footnoted, but I wanted the book to have the intimacy we associate with fiction."

In the streaming era, several different kinds of historical dramas have flourished online. Today, there are streaming shows on the Vikings (Netflix's *Vikings: Valhalla*), the 18th-century Russian royals (*The Great* on Amazon Prime Video), the incumbent British royals (Netflix's *The Crown*), the Ottomans (Netflix's *Rise of Empires: Ottoman*) and so on. In such a crowded genre, how will *The Anarchy* distinguish itself?

"I don't think it's a crowded space," says Dalrymple. "There haven't really been too many representations of the East India Company onscreen. And of the ones we do see, some of them are too caught up with nationalist sentiments. Historical accuracy isn't really a feature. When you look at the British stories of that period (18th and 19th centuries), there are hundreds of BBC dramas, Jane Austen adaptations and so on.... By comparison, the Indian onscreen stories of those eras are not that common."

In August 2022, Dalrymple and Anita Anand (the duo previously co-authored the nonfiction book *Koh-i-Noor*) launched a podcast called *Empire*. Season 1, which ran from August till December last year, covered the rise and fall of the East India Company, the British Raj, Mahatma Gandhi, the Partition, and Independence. Season 2, covering the Ottoman Empire, ended earlier this month. Anand and Dalrymple are now covering the history of slavery across civilisations in the ongoing Season 3, which began on May 4. *Empire* was voted No. 1 on Apple's annual 'Shows That Made Us Think' list.

Asked if the podcast was in competition with his books, Dalrymple said, "We see it as a way of getting to talk to historians whose work we love, and in a way promoting those books."

Dalrymple's greatest strength has been making history accessible for the lay reader, to transform the dreariness of our schoolbooks into page-turning momentum. Within the confines of that project, *The Anarchy* is perhaps his greatest achievement. And with the *Empire* podcast, he and Anand are bringing some of world history's most thrilling chapters to a new generation of listeners. Coincidentally, the day this interview was conducted was also the day Dalrymple finished work on his next book, *The Golden Road*, which brings together three interlinked historical narratives about "Indian influence spreading across the world" (one of the narratives, for example, follows how the Indian numeric system travelled to the rest of the world).

"I think Indian readers should be quite happy with this work," Dalrymple says, with a hearty laugh. ■

Aditya Mani Jha

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

PODCASTS
TO LEND AN EAR TO

THE LIT PICKERS



Writers Deepanjana Pal and Supriya Nair host this sharp, funny, free-flowing podcast where they talk about everything literary—dying genres, underrated authors, posthumous revisions, literature festivals, books that challenged literary establishments and so on. The podcast began life in 2020 and has 25-plus episodes so far, with the latest being released in March last year.

KHANDAAN: A BOLLYWOOD PODCAST



There are bigger and more popular Bollywood podcasts out there, but few have *Khandaan*'s style, encyclopaedic knowledge or easygoing vibe. Hosted by three millennials who eat, sleep and dream Bollywood—Asim Burney, Amrita Rajan and Sujoy Singha—*Khandaan* has had over 180 episodes so far. While Bollywood (especially the movies of the Khan trio) remains the focus, there have been lively discussions on films from other Indian industries too, *Ponniyin Selvan 2*, for example.

NO SUGARCOAT BY POOJA DHINGRA



A renowned pastry chef and owner of the Le15 Patisserie that specialises in macarons and other French desserts, Dhingra started the No SugarCoat podcast in 2018. In it, she discusses different food traditions, recipes and her own journey to chefdom. She invites fellow professional chefs (like Rashmi Uday Singh and Thomas Zacharias) regularly, who talk about the pressures of cooking on strict timelines, running a business in a cut-throat industry and so on.

MAED IN INDIA



One of the few podcasts in the country that focus on indie music, Maed in India is hosted by producer and former RJ Mae Thomas. Every episode features an independent musician (in India or abroad) talking about their music, their inspirations, the conversation ending with acoustic, minimalist versions of their original compositions. This one is for the true music geek interested in every micro-aspect of making music—including tech skills like recording and mixing.